MBA: 8109 RESEARCH METHODS



Week 8: Collecting Primary Data through Interviews, Focus Groups Research Diaries and Questionnaires

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Tonight's objectives and where they land in your research- concept

1. Explain how the research design you chose in Section 3.1 determines the data-collection method and tool
2. Trace every item in a tool back to an objective and a construct in the conceptual framework
3. Distinguish structured, semi-structured, in-depth and group interviews and know when each fits
4. Develop an interview guide and a focus group discussion (FGD) guide for a qualitative strand
5. Place the tool, letter of introduction and consent materials correctly in the appendices

SU Guide, Section 7.2(b): Proposal structure

Chapter 3: Research Methodology

3.1 The Research Design
3.2 Population and Sampling
3.3 Data Collection Methods ◄ tonight
3.4 Data Analysis
3.5 Research Quality
3.7 Ethical Considerations

Appendices

1 Letter of introduction
2 Research instrument(s) ◄ tonight
3 Other information, e.g. population list
4 Timeline of activities

Start with design: the method follows the design

Design in Section 3.1	Typical purpose	Data type	Primary method	Tool in Appendix 2
Descriptive survey / cross-sectional	Describe patterns, levels, prevalence	Quantitative	Self-administered or structured interview survey	Questionnaire (Likert, closed items)
Correlational / explanatory survey	Test relationships between IV, DV, moderator, mediator	Quantitative	Questionnaire; structured interview	Questionnaire built from the operationalisation table
Case study	Understand how and why in a bounded setting	Qualitative (often plus documents)	Semi-structured / in-depth interviews, FGD, document review	Interview guide; FGD guide; document checklist
Exploratory / phenomenological	Find out what is happening; seek new insight	Qualitative	In-depth interviews; focus groups; diaries	Topic guide; diary template
Mixed methods (sequential or convergent)	Explain or validate survey results with depth	Both	Questionnaire + key informant interviews or FGDs	Questionnaire AND interview / FGD guide

Rule of thumb: Standardised interviews feed quantitative analysis; non-standardised interviews feed qualitative analysis. If your design and your tool point to different analyses, the panel will see the mismatch.

The golden thread: keeping the tool in sync

Specific objective (Ch. 1, § 1.3) ▶ **Variable / construct** (Conceptual framework, Ch. 2) ▶ **Indicators** (Operationalisation table) ▶ **Items / questions** (Tool, Appendix 2) ▶ **Analysis** (Ch. 3, § 3.4)

Objective	Construct (CF)	Indicator	Item in questionnaire	Probe in interview guide
To establish the effect of digital banking adoption on customer satisfaction in Tier 1 banks in Nairobi	Digital banking adoption (IV)	Frequency of mobile app use; range of services used	"How often do you use the bank's mobile app?" (Daily … Never)	"Walk me through the last time you chose the app over the branch. Why?"
	Customer satisfaction (DV)	Service reliability; responsiveness; overall satisfaction	Likert: "The app resolves my issues quickly" (1–5)	"What would make you rate the app experience higher?"

Out-of-sync warning signs: items no objective needs ("interesting to know") • a construct in the framework with no items • a moderator drawn in the figure but never measured • questions you cannot analyse with the technique in 3.4

Test: for every item, can you name the objective, the construct and the analysis? If not, delete the item or fix the framework.

Saunders et al., Ch. 10, § 10.1 (nature of the interview must be consistent with research questions, objectives and strategy); Week 3 operationalisation table.

Forms of research interview

Structured (standardised)

- Identical questions, same order, pre-coded answers
- Really an interviewer-administered questionnaire
- Feeds quantitative analysis; survey strategy
- Covered fully next week (Ch. 11)

Semi-structured

- List of themes and key questions per objective
- Order and wording may vary; probes allowed
- Explains relationships between variables
- Most common qualitative tool at MBA level

In-depth (unstructured)

- Informal; a clear idea of the aspect to explore, no fixed list
- Interviewee talks freely around the topic
- Best for exploratory studies
- Demands high interviewer skill

By number of participants and medium

One-to-one	One-to-many	Mediated	Key informant
Face-to-face or telephone	Group interviews; focus groups	Telephone, video call, online / intranet	Purposively chosen, information-rich individuals

Saunders et al., Ch. 10, §10.2 and Figure 10.1 (forms of interview); §10.8 (telephone and internet-mediated interviews).

When interviews are the right choice, and when a questionnaire is

Choose interviews *Semi-structured or in-depth*	Decide on	Stay with a questionnaire *This is most of the class, and that is fine*
Exploratory, or explaining 'why'	**Purpose**	Testing relationships between measured variables
Personal contact builds access and trust	**Respondents**	Large, representative, dispersed sample (§ 3.2)
Many, complex or open-ended; flexible order	**Questions**	Constructs have validated scales in the literature
Long sessions that probe and build on answers	**Session & analysis**	Descriptive and inferential statistics (§ 3.4)

The middle path: a questionnaire for staff or customers plus 4–8 key informant interviews with managers, or 2–3 FGDs, to explain the numbers. Declare it as mixed methods in § 3.1, and put both tools in Appendix 2.

Saunders et al., Ch. 10, § 10.3 and Box 10.3 (checklist to help you decide whether to use semi-structured or in-depth interviews).

Developing an interview guide: anatomy and worked example

A — Opening
Introduce self and study; purpose; duration; consent and permission to record; confidentiality

B — Rapport / background
Role, years in organisation, unit; easy, factual questions

C — Themes by objective
One block per specific objective; 2–4 main questions each

D — Probes
"Can you give an example?" "Why do you think that happened?"

E — Closing
"Anything we have not covered?"; summarise; thank; next steps

Block C example: Objective 2

To examine how leadership style influences employee engagement in private hospitals in Nairobi

C2.1 How would you describe the way decisions are made in your unit?
Probe: Who is involved? Give a recent example.

C2.2 How does your supervisor respond when staff raise ideas or concerns?
Probe: How did that affect your willingness to go the extra mile?

C2.3 What makes you feel committed, or not, to your work here?
Probe: What role does your supervisor play in that?

Construct link: transformational leadership (IV) → engagement: vigour, dedication, absorption (DV)

Saunders et al., Ch. 10, §10.4–10.5 (preparing for the interview; opening, questioning, probing, summarising); Box 10.12 checklist.

Data quality in interviews: threats and how to manage them

Issue	What it means	How to manage it
Reliability (dependability)	Would another researcher uncover similar information?	Keep an audit trail: guide, notes, recordings, transcripts, coding decisions
Interviewer bias	Your tone, comments or non-verbal cues shape answers	Neutral wording; pilot the guide; no leading questions; practise
Interviewee / response bias	Participants withhold or give socially desirable answers	Build credibility and rapport; assure confidentiality; send themes in advance where appropriate
Participation bias	Only certain types of people agree to be interviewed	Purposive criteria from § 3.2; flexible timing and location; report who declined
Validity and generalisability	Do the data reflect the reality studied? Can they inform other settings?	Link findings to theory from Ch. 2; triangulate with documents or survey data; member checking

Record properly: ask permission to audio-record and say why; take notes as back-up; transcribe soon after; store securely in line with SU-ISERC approval.

Saunders et al., Ch. 10, §10.4 (data quality issues: reliability, forms of bias, validity and generalisability).

Focus group discussions (FGDs): a qualitative tool

What an FGD is

A group interview focused clearly on one issue, product, service or topic, where interaction between participants is itself the data. No pressure to reach consensus.

When to use it

- Exploring shared experiences, norms, perceptions
- Generating themes to build questionnaire items
- Explaining survey results in a mixed design

4–8	participants is typical; up to about 12. Fewer for complex or sensitive topics
Purposive	non-probability selection of information-rich people with a shared characteristic
Several	groups with similar participants, so patterns can be compared across them
45min–1 hrs	per session is common; moderator plus a note-taker or observer



Watch for

- Dominant voices and silent members
- Public agreement, private disagreement: a false consensus
- Invitations from managers felt as instructions
- Confidentiality cannot be fully guaranteed in a group
- Breadth of issues, but less depth than one-to-one

Saunders et al., Ch. 10, § 10.7 (group interviews and focus groups) and Box 10.17.

Developing an FGD guide: the question route

Opening 5 min	Round-robin, factual, easy: name, role, years in the sector
Introductory 10 min	Introduce the topic: "What comes to mind when you hear 'digital banking'?"
Transition 10 min	Move to the core: "Think of a recent time you used the app instead of a branch…"
Key questions 45–60 min	3–5 questions, one cluster per objective. Most time here; probe and invite contrasting views
Ending 10 min	Summary check: "Have I captured this correctly?" "What is the most important thing we discussed?"

The guide also records

- Group composition and selection criteria
- Venue, seating, recording set-up
- Moderator script: purpose, ground rules, consent
- Note-taker template: speaker codes, non-verbal cues

Moderator ground rules

- No right or wrong answers
- One person speaks at a time
- Disagreement is welcome
- What is said in the room stays in the room

Question-route structure adapted from Krueger & Casey (2000), cited in Saunders et al., Ch. 10, § 10.7.

Research diaries and remote interviews

Research diaries (participant diaries)

1 Participants record
Experiences, events, feelings; daily or per event

→

2 Diary interview
Explores the entries with the participant

Formats

- **Structured log** — time, event, rating
- **Free-text**
- **Voice note**
- **App entry**

Strength	Captures data close to when it happens, reducing recall bias
Useful for	Routines, workload, customer journeys, change processes
Risk	Drop-off over time, uneven effort: plan reminders, keep entries short
Your diary	Researcher diary of decisions and reflections: an audit trail for reliability

Telephone, video and online interviews

Gains

- Reach dispersed or senior respondents across counties and countries
- Lower cost and travel time; easier scheduling

Watch-outs

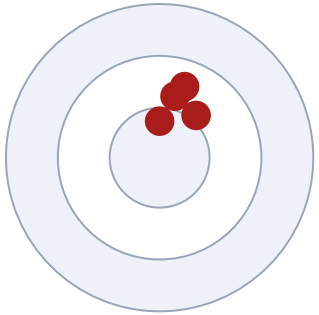
- Harder to build rapport and read non-verbal cues
- Shorter attention span
- Check participants' connectivity and data costs

Before you go remote

1. Obtain consent to record on the platform; store files securely
2. Run online FGDs with smaller groups and a co-host
3. **State the medium in §3.3 and justify it**

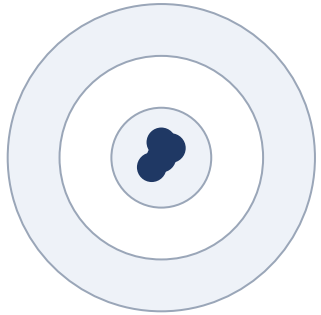
Saunders et al., Ch. 10, § 10.8 (telephone and internet-mediated interviews); Ch. 9 on keeping diaries during observation.

Research quality: reliability and validity



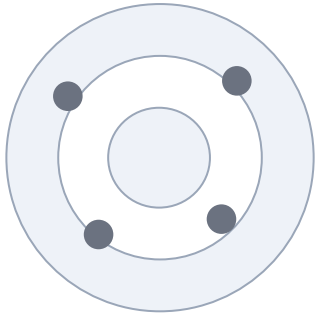
Reliable, not valid

Consistent, but off target: the item measures something else, every time



Valid and reliable

Consistent and on target: this is the goal for every construct



Neither

Scattered and off target: ambiguous items, careless responses

Definitions

- Reliability: consistency. Would the tool give the same results at different times, with different samples or interviewers?
- Validity: accuracy. Does each item measure the construct it claims to measure?

Type of reliability	How it is assessed	When to use it
Internal consistency	Correlate items within one construct; Cronbach's alpha	Every multi-item Likert scale: the default for MBA surveys
Test-retest	Same tool, same people, two points in time; correlate scores	Stable traits; supplement only (hard to get repeat responses)
Alternative form	Equivalent 'check questions' compared within the tool	Long questionnaires; use sparingly (fatigue, copying)
Inter-rater	Agreement between coders or observers (e.g. Cohen's kappa)	Observation schedules; coding qualitative data

A tool must be reliable to be valid, but reliability alone is not enough.

Saunders et al., Ch. 11, § 11.4 (validity and reliability; testing for reliability: test re-test, internal consistency, alternative form, after Mitchell 1996).

Types of validity and how to establish each

Type	Question it answers	How to establish it	When / where
Face validity	Does the tool look sensible to respondents?	Pilot respondents' feedback; colleagues review layout and wording	Pilot stage
Content validity	Do the items adequately cover each construct and the investigative questions?	Derive items from the literature and operationalisation table; expert panel rates each item essential / useful / not necessary (content validity index)	Before the pilot: supervisor and 2–3 subject experts
Construct validity	Do the items measure the construct intended?	Use validated scales; factor analysis (items load ≥ 0.5 on their own construct)	Pilot or main data
▸ **Convergent**	Do items of one construct correlate strongly with each other?	High item loadings; average variance extracted (AVE) ≥ 0.5	Main data, SEM / CFA
▸ **Discriminant**	Is each construct distinct from the others?	Low inter-construct correlations; Fornell–Larcker or HTMT < 0.85	Main data, SEM / CFA
Criterion-related	Do the measures predict or agree with an external criterion?	Correlate scores with an outcome measure (e.g. actual sales, staff turnover)	Concurrent: same time; predictive: later
Internal validity	Can the relationship found be attributed to the IV, not something else?	Control variables from the framework; sound design	Design and analysis
External validity	Can findings generalise to other people or settings?	Probability sampling and adequate sample size (§ 3.2)	Sampling and reporting

Saunders et al., Ch. 11, § 11.4 (content, criterion-related and construct validity, after Cooper & Schindler 2008); Ch. 5 on internal and external validity. Thresholds are common conventions in management research.

Pilot testing and Cronbach's alpha: key considerations

Cronbach's alpha (α)

$$\alpha = (k / (k - 1)) \times (1 - \Sigma\sigma^2_i / \sigma^2_t)$$

k = items in the construct; σ^2_i = variance of each item; σ^2_t = variance of the total score

≥ 0.90	Excellent: check for redundant items
0.80–0.89	Good
0.70–0.79	**Acceptable: the usual threshold**
0.60–0.69	Questionable: revise items
< 0.60	Poor: rework the scale

Threshold: α ≥ 0.70 per construct (Nunnally, 1978). Report α for each construct, not one figure for the whole tool.

The pilot sample

- Saunders: minimum of 10 for most student questionnaires; 100–200 for large surveys
- Common MBA practice: about 10% of the main sample; aim for 30 or more where you will compute alpha, as alpha is unstable in very small samples
- Cover the major variations in your population (e.g. each stratum)
- Expert review for content validity comes first; then the pilot

Exclude from the main study

- Pilot respondents do not take part in the main study: avoids testing effects and contamination
- Draw them from the same population but outside the selected sample, or from a similar entity (e.g. a comparable bank, hospital or county not sampled)
- State this in § 3.5 and in § 3.2
- Revise or drop items with low corrected item-total correlation (< 0.3) or that raise α if deleted; re-pilot if major changes
- Reverse-code negatively worded items before computing α

Saunders et al., Ch. 11, § 11.4 (pilot testing: minimum of 10 after Fink 2003; internal consistency and Cronbach's alpha). Nunnally (1978) Psychometric Theory, 2nd edn.

Digital tools for data collection and how to run it online

Tool	Best for	Offline ?	Cost (check before use)	Watch for
KoboToolbox (KoboCollect app)	Field surveys on phones or tablets; skip logic, GPS, photos	Yes	Free Community plan: 5,000 submissions/month, 1 GB storage	Built on ODK; forms authored in XLSForm or online builder
ODK Collect + ODK Central	Large or multi-site surveys; strong validation and encryption	Yes	Free to self-host (server costs); paid ODK Cloud hosting	Needs a server or subscription; steeper set-up
Google Forms	Quick online surveys of literate, connected respondents	No	Free with a Google account	Basic logic only; one-response limit needs sign-in; data on Google servers
Microsoft Forms	Staff or student surveys inside Microsoft 365	No	Included in institutional M365	Similar limits to Google Forms; good access control
Qualtrics / SurveyMonkey	Complex online surveys, randomisation, panels	Limited	Paid; Qualtrics often via university licence	Free tiers cap questions or responses
Zoom / Teams + transcription	Remote interviews and online FGDs	No	Institutional licences	Consent to record; check transcripts against audio

Running online data collection

1. **Build from the table**
   Each form section = one construct from the operationalisation table
2. **Consent screen first**
   Information sheet, voluntary participation; 'I agree' required to proceed
3. **Validate entries**
   Required fields, value ranges, skip logic, one response per person
4. **Pilot the live link**
   Same link and device mix as the main study; time it
5. **Distribute and monitor**
   Email, WhatsApp, QR code; track daily responses; 2–3 polite reminders
6. **Protect and export**
   Minimal identifiers; restricted access; Kenya Data Protection Act 2019; export to CSV / SPSS

In §3.3 name the platform, mode (online, enumerator-led, mixed) and why it suits your population.

KoboToolbox pricing page and ODK Central documentation, accessed 12 Oct 2026. Saunders et al., Ch. 11, §11.5 (administering the questionnaire).

From Section 3.3 to the appendices: what the panel will look for

Appendix 1
Letter of introduction



To respondents or host organisation: who you are, purpose, voluntary participation, confidentiality, contact details. Attach the participant information and consent form here or with the tool

Common fault

Generic letter that does not name the study or the time required

Appendix 2
Research instrument(s)



Every tool named in § 3.3: questionnaire, interview guide, FGD guide with moderator script, diary template. Label each, e.g. 2A, 2B, 2C

Common fault

Tool missing, or items not traceable to objectives

Appendix 3
Other relevant information



Population list, list of organisations or units, sampling frame, interviewee selection criteria

Common fault

Population in § 3.2 not supported by a source

Appendix 4
Timeline of activities



Piloting, ethics approval, fieldwork, transcription, analysis and write-up, as agreed with the supervisor

Common fault

No time allowed for SU-ISERC approval before fieldwork

Section 3.3 should state: the method(s) and why they fit the design; who is interviewed or in each group and how many; the tool and how it was developed (from the operationalisation table and literature); piloting; medium; recording; who collects data and when. Then: "The instrument is attached as Appendix 2."

SU Guide to Research for Masters Theses, Dissertations and Projects, § 7.2(b): Chapter 3 structure and Appendices 1–4.

Practical (40 min) and the road to Week 10

Build your Tool Alignment Matrix

Step 1 (5 min): Write your design from § 3.1 and the method it implies (Slide 3).

Step 2 (15 min): Draw a five-column table: Objective | Construct | Indicator | Item or interview question | Analysis. Fill it for two objectives.

Step 3 (10 min): Questionnaire users: draft 3 items per construct and name the scale. Qualitative or mixed: draft Block C of an interview guide or the key questions of an FGD guide.

Step 4 (10 min): Swap with a neighbour. Each marks any item that cannot be traced to an objective, and any construct with no item.

Take-aways

- Design → method → tool, in that order
- Every item traces to an objective and a construct
- FGDs and interviews are qualitative; analyse them as such
- Every tool in § 3.3 appears in Appendix 2

Next: Week 10 (from 19 Oct)

- Collecting primary data using questionnaires (Saunders Ch. 11)
- Bring your alignment matrix: we turn it into a full questionnaire
- Read: types of questionnaire; deciding what data to collect; designing and piloting